two big cats remains embedded in cultural memory even as the animals themselves face extinction.

Sadly, there are now a mere 411 Asiatic lions left in the wild. [10] The Gir National Park in Gujarat is their last refuge. Less than two hundred years ago, this magnificent beast could be found around Delhi and were probably common in the Aravalli ridges south of Gurgaon. Now eight-lane highways roar though the lion's erstwhile lair. The last reported sighting of a lion in Iran was in 1942. In Iraq, the magnificent Assyrian friezes are all that remain of a beast last sighted in 1917. [11]

THE LATE IRON AGE

By the late Iron Age (eighth to fifth century BC), we find that a number of urban clusters are reaching scales that are comparable to the Harappan cities. Kausambi, near today's Allahabad, is said to have been founded after the king of Hastinapur, a descendant of the Pandavas, who was forced by a devastating flood to shift his capital further east. Spread over an area of 150-200 hectares, Kausambi had a population of around 36,000 people at its height. [12] Other major cities like Rajagir and Sravasti were on a similar scale. These are comparable to Mohenjodaro, the largest of the Harappan sites, which had a population of around 40,000. It is difficult to estimate the total population of the subcontinent at this time but it was probably in the range of 30 million.

The late Iron Age towns were fortified with moats and ramparts. Wood and mud-bricks were the common building material but the Harappan technology of kiln-fired bricks had not been forgotten. Kausambi, for instance, shows extensive use of kiln-fired bricks. The towns also have drains, soakage pits and other urban amenities, albeit of a design that is different from the Indus Valley era. However, the courtyard continues to be the basic prototype for houses while streets were systematically levelled to allow wheeled traffic.